

Nokia N900 tablet

Dubbed as the RX-51, the internet was full of leaked shots of the upcoming Nokia N900, the successor to the N810. This is interesting news because there has been little happening in the tablet space. Secondly, this bulky beast will be one of the first devices to sport the Maemo 5 OS, codenamed Fremantle - Tux fanboys will clap their hands in glee since the platform is based on Linux. Nokia has been working with members of the Maemo community and Linux mobile developers for some time now. In fact, Maemo 5 represents a lot of push from Nokia's side to bring about architectural changes.

We're saving the spoilers on the hardware for last and now a little more dope on Maemo 5. A unique hardware and boot management system called "Upstart" is being used. Being event driven and asynchronous, it can perform multiple tasks simultaneously and is much better than the current iterative system that performs operations in a predetermined order. So Maemo starts up faster. The open hardware manager (OHM) is next. This hardware abstraction layer (HAL) provides a standardised interface for managing the device's internal functionality, such as reducing back lighting automatically in case of low battery or under-clocking the processor in case of excessive heat dissipation. Disabling the power button during a firmware flash is one other such example. It is completely user configurable and features rule-based policies.

The most excitement is generated by the connectivity options that Maemo 5 supports. Nokia has opened its source code for high speed



packet access (HSPA) and the Wi-Fi driver for tablets to the development community in the pursuit of getting these into the Linux kernel. Then there is the "Clutter" graphics framework, which brings richer and more

has become a Nokia *de facto* now. The N900 should make a splash later this year, probably at Nokia World 2009 scheduled for September. Rumours have it's pricing at around the \$599 mark, which seems about

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interactive and attractive menu systems, visual effects, and of course, usability.

And now for the N900; how does a massive 3.5-inch resistive-touch based touchscreen with a hefty resolution of 800 x 480 pixels sound? The 32 GB built-in memory, 5 MP camera, Wi-Fi, Bluetooth, GPS, micro USB and TV-out are fresh out of the N97 oven. Did we mention a full, slide-out QWERTY keypad? Processing grunt comes from an ARM Cortex-A8 CPU that is clocked at anywhere 550 and 650 MHz (Nokia is keeping this hush for now). No news on the battery, but we expect nothing less than a colossal 1,500 mAh unit, perhaps something even larger given that this will be used for heavy connectivity.

Reviewers who have got a sneak peek say the Maemo 5 interface is fun, rich and very usable, not to mention an excellent performer and better than the Symbian S60 platform that

right for the features and performance on offer.

Nokia's rural love - new micro-payment scheme

Amid pandemic scares and global recession, as fortunes continue to dwindle it seems Nokia is the one shining star that threatens to emerge from all this even stronger than it was a year ago. Nokia's Indian market continues to grow even as pockets shrink and kudos to their marketing division for coming up with innovative ways to reel in even more customers.

India is already Nokia's second biggest market with 430 million users - a whopping 60 per cent of India's cellphones are Nokias. While the demand for high-end phones remains the domain of urban India, Nokia has a new lucrative micro-financing scheme that should reign in more of the rural audience as well. The new scheme, which has already been tested in Maharashtra, will enable rural

customers to pay for their mobile in 25 equal weekly installments of Rs. 100 each. This service is sure to be a boon to many of the customers in the rural market, as now with a small bill of Rs. 400 above their monthly bill, they can get a Nokia mobile. Other schemes, such as Nokia Life Tools, are also targeted towards this market. With the Nokia Life Tools Agriculture services, Nokia intends to provide its rural audience with information relevant to them. Connectivity is always a good thing, and more services geared for farmers and other rural audiences is surely a good sign. Just don't expect to get an N97 in this scheme anytime soon!

When giants meet

Nokia, the worldwide leader in smart-phones and Microsoft, the largest software manufacturer in the world, have combined forces and entered into an alliance that is set to deliver a groundbreaking, enterprise-grade solution for mobile productivity. In mid-August, Microsoft Business Division President Stephen Elop and Nokia's Executive Vice President for Devices, Kai Oistamo, announced the agreement and outlined a shared vision for the future of mobile productivity.

The two giants have already begun collaborating on the design, development and marketing of productivity solutions for the mobile professional, bringing Microsoft Office Mobile and Microsoft business communications, collaboration and device management software to Nokia's Symbian devices. These solutions will be available for a broad range of Nokia smart-phones, starting with the E-series. Both Microsoft and Nokia possess a rare combination of enterprise experience and consumer understanding and, in addition to the collaboration on existing software and services, will use these assets to jointly design a

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